

Linux Class 4 - Task

Exact Word Replace in vi, the Fourth Occurrence, and man vs --help

For practice I made a folder called class4 and made two small files inside it with vi. The file exact.txt has the two lines that were given in the question, and greet.txt has a list of greetings. I used exact.txt for the first question and greet.txt for the second one.

1. How to search and replace an exact pattern?

This was the file I had to work on:

```
hello all good morning
goodmorning good morning
```

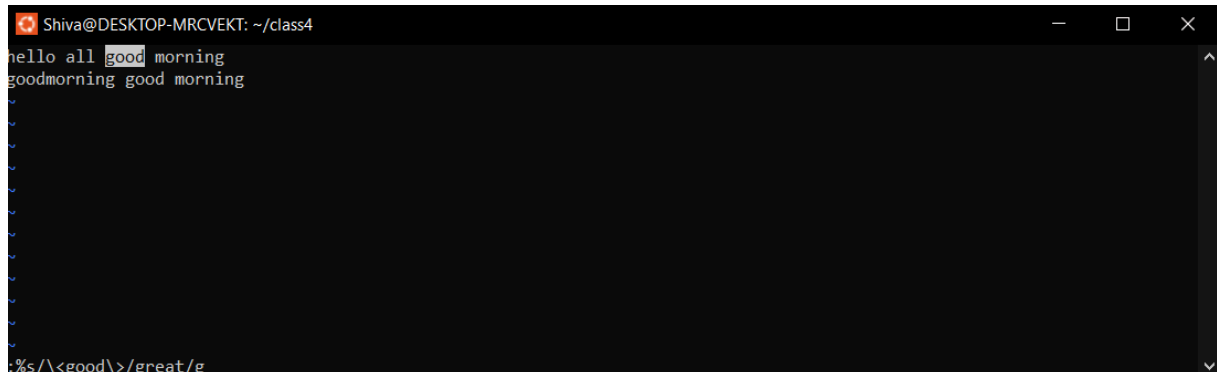
If I simply type `:%s/good/great/g` then vi also changes the good that is inside goodmorning, because good is a part of that word. That is not what I want. I only want the word good when it is standing alone.

So I put `\<` and `\>` around the word:

```
:%s/\<good\>/great/g
```

- `\<` means the beginning of a word.
- `\>` means the end of a word.

Together they tell vi that good must be a full word by itself, not a part of a longer word. This is called an exact word match.



Screenshot 1: The file before, with the command typed at the bottom.

After pressing Enter both the separate good words became great, but goodmorning stayed the same, because there the good is joined to morning.



Screenshot 2: Only the full word good changed. goodmorning is not touched.

2. How to search and replace only the 4th occurrence in vi editor?

In vi there is no option where I can say change only number 4. So instead I first go to the 4th one and then change only that one word. These are the steps I did:

1. Press Esc so that vi is in command mode.
2. Type `/good` and press Enter. The cursor goes to the 1st good.
3. Press `n` three more times. Now the cursor is on the 4th good.
4. Press `cw`, which means change word, then type the new word and press Esc.

My file `greet.txt` had `good` written five times. After the search and three `n` presses the cursor was on `good night`, which is the 4th one. The numbers on the right side showed line 5, and that is the line I wanted.



Screenshot 3: After `/good` and pressing `n` three times, the cursor is on the 4th good.

Then I pressed `cw` and typed `great` and pressed Esc. Only that one word changed to `great`. All the other `good` words in the file stayed the same.



Screenshot 4: Only the 4th one became `great night`. The rest are still `good`.

3. What is the difference between `man` and `--help` command?

Both of them are used to know how a command works, but they are not the same thing.

`man` means manual. It is a separate command. It opens a full manual page of the command in a reading screen:

```
man ls
```

At the bottom it showed Manual page `ls(1)` line 1, and it stayed on that screen until I pressed `q` to come out.

```

Shiva@DESKTOP-MRCVEKT: ~/class4
LS(1) General Commands Manual LS(1) ^
NAME
ls - List directory contents. Ignore files and directories starting with a '.' by default

SYNOPSIS
ls [--help] [--format] [-C] [-l|--long] [-x] [-T|--tabsize] [-m] [--zero] [-D|--dired] [--hyperlink] [-1]
[-o] [-g] [-n|--numeric-uid-gid] [--quoting-style] [-N|--literal] [-b|--escape] [-Q|--quote-name]
[-q|--hide-control-chars] [--show-control-chars] [--time] [-c] [-u] [--hide] [-I|--ignore] [-B|--ignore-back-
ups] [--sort] [-S] [-t] [-v] [-X] [-U] [-L|--dereference] [--dereference-command-line-symlink-to-dir]
[-H|--dereference-command-line] [-G|--no-group] [--author] [-a|--all] [-A|--almost-all] [-f] [-d|--directory]
[-h|--human-readable] [-k|--kibibytes] [--si] [--block-size] [-i|--inode] [-r|--reverse] [-R|--recursive]
[-w|--width] [-s|--size] [--color] [--indicator-style] [-F|--classify] [--file-type] [-p] [--time-style]
[--full-time] [-Z|--context] [--group-directories-first] [-V|--version] [paths]
Manual page ls(1) line 1 (press h for help or q to quit)

```

Screenshot 5: man ls opens the full manual with NAME and SYNOPSIS.

--help is not a separate command. It is an option of the command itself. The command prints a short help and comes straight back to the prompt:

```
ls --help
```

The help of ls is long, so I used head to show only the first 11 lines.

```

Shiva@DESKTOP-MRCVEKT: ~/class4
Shiva@DESKTOP-MRCVEKT:~/class4$ ls --help | head -11
List directory contents.
Ignore files and directories starting with a '.' by default

Usage: ls [OPTION]... [FILE]...

Options:
  --help
    Print help information.
  --format <format>
    Set the display format.
  -C
Shiva@DESKTOP-MRCVEKT:~/class4$

```

Screenshot 6: ls --help prints a short help and returns to the prompt.

The main differences are:

man	--help
A separate program that opens the manual page written for the command.	An option that is built inside the command itself.
Long and full. It has NAME, SYNOPSIS, DESCRIPTION, OPTIONS and more.	Short. Usually just the usage line and the list of options.
Opens in a reading screen. I move with the arrow keys and press q to quit.	Prints on the screen and comes straight back to the prompt.
Works only if the manual pages are installed on the system.	Works only if the command supports it. Some commands use -h instead.

So I use --help when I only want to check an option quickly, and man when I want to read and understand the command properly.

Commands I used

Command	What it does
:%s/good/great/g	Changes good everywhere, even inside a bigger word.
:%s/\<good\>/great/g	Changes only the full word good.
/good	Searches forward for good.

Command	What it does
n	Goes to the next one. Pressing it three times takes me to the 4th.
cw	Changes the word the cursor is on.
man ls	Opens the full manual of ls. Press q to come out.
ls --help	Prints a short help of ls on the screen.